

Career success tips

The Myth of More: Why We Need a New Career Wisdom



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The season of career advice is upon us once again. Graduation speeches, LinkedIn posts, and mentorship moments abound with guidance for those starting or advancing their careers. And unfortunately, I've noticed a troubling pattern in most of these well-intentioned messages: do more, hustle harder, outwork everyone around you.

Sound familiar?

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professional achievement. We're told to "lean in," be the first to arrive and last to leave, and always raise our hands for more responsibility.

But at what cost?

The complicated legacy of well-intentioned advice

Let me be clear — this advice usually comes from a good place. I've seen posts like these from successful people who genuinely want to help others achieve similar heights. They're sharing what worked for them, the behaviors they've observed in high-achievers, and the metrics by which they've measured their own success.

Many of us have built our careers following these principles. I've done it myself. We've evaluated job candidates based on their willingness to "go above and beyond." We've praised team members who answer emails at 11pm. We've admired the colleague who stays fully connected while on vacation.

But we need to ask ourselves: Are we okay perpetuating a system that's burning us out? Are we comfortable passing down traditions that have left so many of us exhausted, disconnected from our families, and struggling with our health?

The burnout reality

I'm part of Gen X — a generation that the recent [Lyra Empowering the Workforce of Tomorrow report](#) aptly says is "holding up everyone but themselves." We're the generation that has internalized this message so completely that we're now simultaneously managing aging parents, supporting adult children, driving digital transformation at work, and trying

The report reveals a sobering reality: only 14% of Gen X feels they've saved enough for retirement. We're caught in a caregiving crunch, with more than 70% of middle-aged Americans caring for both children and parents. We've become the ultimate multitaskers — and we're exhausted.

Even **Sheryl Sandberg**, who famously encouraged women to "lean in" to their careers, later acknowledged the limitations of her advice. After experiencing personal tragedy and seeing how her guidance failed to address systemic challenges, she adjusted her message, admitting that it's simply not possible to "lean in" when you're struggling to stand-up.

Why are we passing down this legacy of hustle to the next generation when we can see its consequences so clearly in our own lives?

The AI revolution and our human response

As we navigate these questions about work and purpose, there's another factor reshaping our landscape: artificial intelligence.

The rapid advancement of AI and automation is transforming industries, eliminating certain tasks, and creating new possibilities. For many, this technological shift triggers anxiety — will AI make our jobs obsolete, or demand we work even harder to keep up?

I see it differently. Perhaps AI offers us an unexpected opportunity to reconsider the very nature of work and our relationship to it.

When repetitive tasks can be automated and information can be processed at unprecedented speeds, what remains uniquely human becomes more valuable: creativity, emotional intelligence, ethical judgment, and meaningful connection.

could work alongside them, delegating the mundane while reclaiming time for deeper thinking and genuine innovation.

This technological revolution coincides with a generational reevaluation of work-life priorities. Maybe that's not a coincidence but an invitation to reimagine what truly matters.

For Gen X, caught in the caregiving crunch described in the Lyra report, AI tools might help manage information overload and administrative burdens. For younger generations, AI could enable the flexibility and purpose-driven work they're seeking. For Baby Boomers extending their careers, these technologies might allow greater accessibility and connection.

A revolution of values

What if there's a better way? What if success isn't about adding more, but about aligning with what truly matters?

The emerging workforce is already questioning this hustle mentality. Gen Z values flexibility, mental health support, and inclusivity as essential to a fulfilling work life. They're leaving toxic workplaces and prioritizing wellbeing in ways previous generations couldn't imagine.

Perhaps they're onto something.

Instead of advising young professionals to be "the one who outworks everyone else," what if we encouraged them to be:

- The most *discerning person* in the room: Able to identify what truly matters and what doesn't
- The most *balanced person* in the room: Demonstrating that sustainable performance requires recovery

- The *most collaborative* person in the room: Building others up instead of competing for limited resources
- The *most resilient* person in the room: Not because they never falter, but because they know how to reset and adapt

What I wish someone had told me

If I could travel back in time and give advice to my younger self, it wouldn't be to work harder. I'd say:

1. Define success holistically: Career advancement is just one dimension of a meaningful life, not the whole picture.
2. Set boundaries early: The work will always expand to fill the time you give it. Decide what's enough.
3. Quality over quantity: Your most valuable contributions will rarely come from the times you were most depleted.
4. Build in recovery: Sustainable high performance requires intentional rest and renewal.
5. Cultivate relationships outside work: Your support system will sustain you through career ups and downs.
6. Trust your inner wisdom: Sometimes the most productive thing you can do is step back and reassess.

The five-generation workforce described in that Lyra report presents both challenges and opportunities. As leaders, we can perpetuate the cycle of burnout, or we can model a more sustainable approach to work and life.

This isn't about lowering our standards or ambitions. It's about being more intentional with our energy and attention. It's about keeping what serves us and our larger purpose while having the courage to let go of what doesn't.

Finding hope at the intersection of technology and humanity

There's something deeply hopeful about this moment we're in. Technology is evolving at breathtaking speed, while simultaneously, we're witnessing a profound shift in how we think about work and success.

When we move away from defining success through eternal hustle and constant expansion, we create space for more meaningful achievement and genuine fulfillment. And when we embrace AI as a tool for augmenting our humanity rather than replacing it, we open up new possibilities for how we work and live.

The workplace is changing rapidly. The next decade will welcome Gen Alpha, with their digital-first mindset, alongside four other generations with different needs and expectations. According to the Lyra report, by the early 2030s, Gen Alpha will make up 11% of the global workforce — the first generation fully raised in the 21st century.

The organizations that thrive won't be those demanding the most hours or perpetuating burnout culture. Success will come to those that help employees across all generations find sustainable ways to contribute their best while honoring their whole lives — and that thoughtfully integrate AI to enhance human potential rather than diminish it.

So the next time you see that post telling you to hustle harder or sacrifice more, remember there's another way. One that honors your humanity, protects your wellbeing, and ultimately leads to more meaningful success.

This post was first published in Jen's **Thoughts on Well Being newsletter**.

Jen Fisher is Founder and CEO of The Wellbeing Team and a globally recognized authority on workplace wellbeing and human sustainability. Her transformative journey from burnout to breakthrough has established her as a visionary leader in reimagining work culture.

As **Deloitte** U.S.'s **pioneering first Chief Wellbeing Officer**, Fisher developed an innovative, holistic wellbeing strategy that earned widespread recognition. Her personal experiences with burnout and cancer have shaped her passionate advocacy for comprehensive workplace health.

A driving force behind the wellbeing intelligence movement and co-creator of WellQ360, Fisher guides C-suite executives across industries in developing strategies that bridge generational gaps and create value for both individuals and organizations. Her systems thinking approach integrates culture, leadership, team dynamics, and individual experiences to maximize existing investments.

Fisher's expertise has been showcased through keynotes at TEDx and global conferences, guest lectures at Harvard and Duke, and as author of the bestselling "**Work Better Together**." She is the creator and host of the award winning **The WorkWell Podcast** series.

Her forthcoming book, "Hope is the Strategy" (2026), explores hope as a foundational leadership skill that drives organizational success and wellbeing.

Subscribe to her insights at **jenfisher.substack.com**.



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